CHAPTER ONE

The Crossing

The ferry at Holm Ness runs twice a day in summer and once in winter, and for forty years it was run by a woman named Agnes Thorne.[1] She was the third of her family to hold the licence, and she held it longer than anyone before her.

The crossing takes twenty minutes when the tide is slack and nearly an hour when it is not. Agnes knew the water so well that she could tell the state of the tide from the colour of the weed on the landing stage. "Green going brown," she would say, "we'll be late," and we always were.

She kept a ledger of every passenger she ever carried. It ran to nine volumes. The entries are short: a name, a date, a fare, and now and then a remark such as *sang the whole way* or *would not pay; let him off*.[2]

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1. The licence was first granted to her grandmother, Ruth Thorne, in 1889.

2. The ledgers are now in the county record office at Bramwell.

In the winter of 1963 the strait froze for the first time in living memory, and for nine days Agnes could not cross. People walked over the ice instead, carrying parcels and children, and she stood on the landing stage and watched them go. She told me it was the worst week of her life. “They didn't need me,” she said. “That's a terrible thing to find out about yourself.”

When the ice broke, she took the ferry out before dawn, alone, and crossed and recrossed the strait six times. Asked afterward why she had done it, she said she wanted the water to remember who it belonged to.[3]

3. This remark is recorded in the Bramwell Gazette of 2 February 1963, though the reporter attributes it to “a local boatwoman”.

CHAPTER TWO

The Bridge

The bridge was first proposed in 1971 and finally opened in 1988. Agnes attended every public meeting held about it in those seventeen years, and spoke at most of them. She was not against the bridge, she said; she was against forgetting.

On the day it opened she made her last crossing, carrying the mayor, two councillors and a brass band, which played the whole way over. In the ledger, under the final entry, she wrote a single line: *Fare paid in full.*[4]

4. The ferry itself was sold to a museum on the mainland, where it can still be seen.